



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

partners, and China.

To consolidate and maintain India's technological leadership globally, there is a need to invest in higher education—to increase access, equity, and affordability and improve the quality of India's institutions. The nation must focus on producing specialists by expanding the pipeline of PhD and Master's scholars in science and technology.

Premium quality research is also essential to maintaining an innovation pipeline. India lags behind other economies in research and innovation spending and must deploy timely resources to remedy this. Technology will accelerate every socio-economic growth engine, and India cannot afford to fall behind in developing these platforms.

The National Education Policy

2020 provides a future-oriented framework for R&D, including the oft-mentioned National Research Foundation (NRF) with an initial outlay of ₹50,000 crore over five years. When instituted, the NRF will fund academic research to create the pipeline towards productisation and deployment of world-class technology, similar to how the US and, more recently, China have maintained their tech leadership.

As a leading power in the digital world, the focus must also include digitally disseminating all government services to all citizens. Citizens must be empowered through devices and data plans to access those services, and critical services like education and health services must be available to anyone seeking them. Overall, the cost of empowering oneself through government services will reduce via technology platforms, reducing the wastage accompanying physical transactions.

India's technological achievements—particularly in the digital realm—form a formidable base for its trajectory over the next 25 years and beyond. While we can be optimistic about India's technological prowess and capacity for innovation, we must keep in mind that innovation cycles are reducing drastically. Significant discoveries could crop out of nowhere and make current protocols and frameworks redundant. There is a need to stay vigilant and abreast of the latest findings and invest sufficiently in R&D so that India can remain at the forefront of these advancements. **BT**

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